

World in Brief: America's tariff on Canadian goods; Iran's "position of power"



Photograph: AFP

America imposed a **50% tariff on some Canadian goods** entering the country after the two countries failed to reach a deal. The levy, which affects about \$20bn-worth of imports, was planned for Wednesday, but Mr Trump held it up for three days to give time for negotiations. Canada suspended talks at the eleventh hour. Mark Carney, Canada's prime minister, threatened to retaliate "dollar for dollar".

Masoud Pezeshkian, Iran's president, said that now would be a good time to end the war with America, while Iran was in a "position of power and dignity". Earlier **Iran** threatened "devastating responses" to any miscalculation by its "enemies", after Donald Trump promised the strongest-ever sanctions against the Islamic Republic. The Trump administration is expected to give details on Monday.

Gold and silver prices rose on Friday as markets worried that America's Treasury would not be able to keep **long-term bond yields** down. On Wednesday it pledged to [buy back more debt](#). Bitcoin also rose by around 6%. The yield on 30-year Treasuries

dropped briefly after the announcement. While it has not returned to a recent high of 5.34%, it has crept back up.

Citadel, a hedge fund, offloaded more than 80% of the “aggregate risk” it took on from **Situational Awareness**, a smaller AI-focussed fund that [found itself in distress](#) last month. Ken Griffin, Citadel’s boss, said that it had done almost 100 block trades worth over \$4bn. It probably made a tidy profit doing so.

TikTok and ByteDance, its Chinese parent company, agreed to pay \$400m to settle a lawsuit alleging that the short-video app had violated a law that protects children’s privacy. In 2024 America’s Justice Department sued, alleging that TikTok collected data on millions of users under the age of 13. Meta, a social-media company, is currently fighting a lawsuit alleging that it broke the same law, [among others](#).

America’s Supreme Court allowed the construction of Mr Trump’s \$400m **White House ballroom** project to continue, for now. Building work was supposed to stop this weekend to comply with a lower-court ruling that Congress should authorise the structure’s completion. The Trump administration appealed against that decision, arguing that [the ballroom](#) is needed for national security. The justices are still weighing the arguments.

A man killed one person and injured three others with a **sword** at a high school in **Sweden**. Police said the suspect had been detained. The attack follows a mass shooting that killed ten people at an adult-education centre last year—the worst in the country’s history. Sweden has also been rocked by a series of stabbings in schools, including in 2022 and in 2015.

Correction: In a previous edition we said that Scott Bessent, America’s treasury secretary, made bond buybacks on Wednesday. In fact he announced them on Wednesday, and they will take place over the next few months.

Word of the week: *Ongaku kissa*, a Japanese music café. Read how these venues, commonly known as listening bars or hi-fi bars, [are striking a chord abroad](#).

Have you been following the headlines? Test your knowledge of the news with [our weekly quiz](#).

China wants its humanoids to be taken seriously



Photograph: Getty Images

The World Robot Conference, which began in Beijing this week, is an opportunity for [China's growing humanoid sector](#) to show off. Robots there perform ballet, box and play ping pong. While these androids can grab attention in a conference centre, exhibitors want to prove that their machines are useful, too.

China has the world's most extensive supply chain for humanoids. Nearly all 14,500 automatons delivered last year globally came from the country. But few can do more than dance. Demonstrating that robots can also fold laundry and take things off of shelves could help the industry to become a viable business. Engineers are putting more emphasis on the robots' software, which is the one area where China still lags behind its leading American competitors. It will take some time until humanoids are able to work in care homes and factories. At least there is entertainment during the wait.

Montenegro takes a step closer to EU membership



Photograph: Getty Images

Political corruption has long troubled Montenegro. This week a parliamentary committee approved sweeping constitutional amendments, expected to be ratified in the coming days, to tackle it. Two provisions stand out. Ministers charged with corruption will no longer be immune from criminal prosecution. And candidates for minister must undergo “integrity checks”.

Passing the package, which the European Commission has endorsed, will help Montenegro further [its case to join the European Union](#). The tiny Balkan country ambitiously hopes this will happen by 2028; it has been negotiating membership since 2012. Talks have been prolonged, in part, because European officials have sought proof of a proper fight against organised crime and corruption. The amendments may help convince Brussels, but they are less popular among some Montenegrins. Human-rights activists argue that lawmakers are more focused on ticking Europe’s boxes than meaningfully cracking down on corruption. An invitation for public input on the amendments was, they say, just a formality.

Britain's vanishing craft of marionette-making



Photograph: Little Angel Theatre

By all commercial logic, the craft of making marionettes—wooden puppets controlled by strings—should have disappeared long ago. Only a handful of Britons still carve these elaborate figures for a living, giving the centuries-old trade a place on the country's list of endangered heritage skills.

But it's not extinct. In part that's because of the Little Angel Theatre in London, a children's puppetry house. It's one of few in the world with a marionette bridge, an elevated platform from which puppeteers perform. On Saturday the theatre will showcase the work of British puppet-makers, spanning the 65 years since it first opened.

Europe has more marionette-makers, and more performances. The Salzburg Marionette Theatre in Austria still stages full-scale ballets and operas using only string puppets. France hosts a biennial festival for string puppetry in Charleville-Mézières, which attracts thousands of spectators. Much like Pinocchio, history's most famous marionette, this vanishing art continues to captivate.

Can sports handle the heat?



Photograph: Getty Images

Extreme heat is causing problems for athletes. The biggest challenge is to identify the point at which uncomfortably high temperatures become hazardous, and to lessen the danger. Sports governing bodies are suggesting solutions. FIFA introduced “[hydration breaks](#)” during this year’s World Cup—although fans criticised them as glorified advertising breaks. Formula One is giving drivers cooling vests, but racers’ opinions on their effectiveness are mixed.

The next test comes during a summer of [punishing heatwaves in Europe](#). On Saturday the Vuelta a España, a prestigious cycling race, begins in Monaco. Most of it takes place in Andalusia, Spain’s hottest region. If temperatures climb too high, the Union Cycliste Internationale, which governs professional cycling, could instruct the Vuelta to shorten or cancel a stage; this year the Tour de France cut a time trial by 30km because of heat. Such a solution might upset Javier Guillén, the race’s director, who argues that heat is “part of the competition”.

Weekend profile: Mike Ashley, the blokeish billionaire buying into luxury



Photograph: Alamy

Mike Ashley's name is not synonymous with refinement. The 61-year-old British billionaire built a fortune from Sports Direct, a bargain sportswear chain. He holds business meetings in pubs and challenges subordinates to drinking contests, once allegedly vomiting into a fireplace having sunk 12 pints. After purchasing Newcastle United football club, he made a point of watching from the stands, rather than the director's box. A video online shows him downing a pint of beer impressively quickly during a match.

Now Mr Ashley is bingeing on luxury firms. This week his conglomerate, Frasers Group, revealed it had built a 48% stake in [Hugo Boss](#), Germany's biggest upmarket fashion firm, falling just short of overall control. The board had recommended shareholders reject his offer. Last week Frasers bought Harvey Nichols, a posh but struggling chain of British department stores. In July it disclosed a 4% stake in Burberry, a luxury label.

The world of high fashion is a long way from Mr Ashley's first forays in business. After leaving school at 16 with just one qualification (a C grade in economics), he had dreams of becoming a squash player. Injuries put paid to that. His parents then remortgaged the family bungalow to lend him £10,000 (\$17,500 at the time), with which he set up a sports shop. By 2006 his chain

had become Britain's biggest sportswear retailer, in part by buying the merchandise of well-known brands that distressed sellers were offloading cheaply.

Some of Mr Ashley's business tactics fit his bruiser image. In 2007 he sold a 43% stake in Sports Direct, raising £929m. A few months later the shares had lost half their value; he called unhappy investors "cry babies". In 2016, following investigations into Sports Direct's working conditions, he admitted some warehouse workers had been paid below minimum wage. A year later an investment banker took him to court alleging that, during a "night of heavy drinking", Mr Ashley promised but subsequently failed to pay him £15m if he could help Sports Direct's share price to hit £8. Mr Ashley won on the grounds that the offer was not serious. "I like to get drunk. I'm a power drinker," he explained during the trial.

In 2022 Mr Ashley handed over day-to-day running of Frasers to his soon-to-be son-in-law, Michael Murray. It is he who is reportedly behind the shift away from budget offerings. But Mr Ashley still relishes a corporate scrap. This month, when asked by the *Financial Times* about his battle to take over Hugo Boss, he promised them "a bit of Dunkirk spirit".

Mini crossword

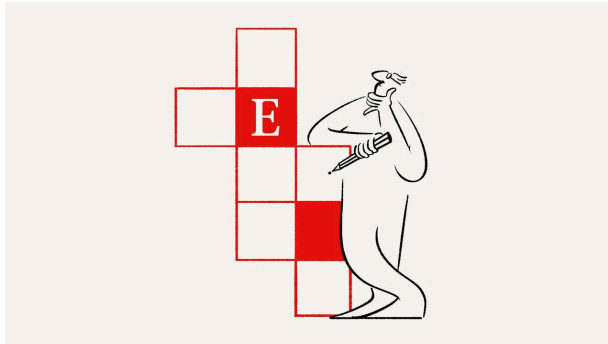


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - One deed consumes politician. It's a shock (6)

2 across - Let go of old drug boat (5)

3 across - New molar is crooked - typical! (6)

1 down - Trendy group swaps American for English disease (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Effect, influence (6)

2 across - Light boat (5)

3 across - Typical (6)

1 down - Contamination (9)

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Julian Cooper, Aylesbury, Britain

Ezra Miller, Ottawa, Canada

José Miguel Ried, Santiago, Chile

They all gave the correct answers of: Walk the Line, corner a market, The Caucasian Chalk Circle, Area 51 and “Out, damned spot”. The theme is parts of a football pitch: goal (or half-way) line, corner arc, centre circle and penalty area and spot.

The questions were:

Monday: Which Johnny Cash song was adapted as the title of the 2005 biopic of the country singer?

Tuesday: What term, familiar from geometry, is used to describe the act of acquiring the bulk of a commodity's supply so as to drive up the price?

Wednesday: Which play by Bertolt Brecht is about a peasant girl who rescues a baby?

Thursday: Which American air-force base in Nevada is the subject of many conspiracy theories about alien visitors?

Friday: Which phrase does Lady Macbeth utter in Shakespeare's play as she tries to rub imaginary blood off her hands?

*The first thing I do in the morning
is brush my teeth and sharpen my
tongue.*

Dorothy Parker